Common English Phrases for Office Meetings

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SEO essentials

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Speaking up in an English meeting can feel intimidating — you know what you want to say, but finding the right words fast enough is hard. The good news: **meetings follow predictable moments — opening, giving an opinion, agreeing, disagreeing, clarifying, and wrapping up — so if you learn a few ready-made phrases for each, you'll always have something professional to say.**

Think of these as building blocks you can grab instantly, so your energy goes into your idea rather than scrambling for words. Below are the most useful phrases, grouped by the moment you'll need them.

Starting the meeting and giving updates

To open or get started:

- "Thanks everyone for joining. Shall we get started?"
- "Today I'd like to cover three things…"

- “Let’s begin with the first item on the agenda.”

To give your update:

- “I’ll give you a quick update on…”
- “Where we are right now is…”
- “The main progress since last time is…”
- “One thing I want to flag is…”

To hand over:

- “That’s it from me — I’ll pass it over to [name].”
- “I’d be happy to go into more detail if useful.”

Giving opinions, agreeing, and disagreeing

To give your opinion:

- “In my opinion…” / “From my point of view…”
- “I think we should…”
- “What I’d suggest is…”

To agree:

- “I completely agree.”
- “That’s a good point.”
- “Yes, exactly — and I’d add that…”

To disagree politely (the key word is *politely* — soften it):

- “I see your point, but…”
- “I’m not sure I agree, because…”
- “That’s one option, though another way to look at it is…”
- “I’d push back on that slightly — what about…?”

Disagreeing in English usually starts by acknowledging the other person first. Jumping straight to “No, you’re wrong” sounds harsh; “I see your point, but…” keeps it professional.

Interrupting and clarifying

To interrupt politely:

- “Sorry to jump in, but…”
- “Can I add something here?”
- “Just quickly on that point…”

To ask for clarification (never pretend you understood — asking is normal and professional):

- “Sorry, could you clarify what you mean by…?”
- “Just to make sure I understand — are you saying…?”
- “Could you give an example?”
- “Sorry, could you repeat that last part?”

To check others understood you:

- “Does that make sense?”
- “Let me know if I should explain that differently.”
- “Are we all on the same page?”

If you miss something, ask. Everyone — native speakers included — asks people to repeat things in meetings.

Making suggestions and wrapping up

To make a suggestion:

- “Why don’t we…?”
- “How about we…?”
- “It might be worth…”
- “One option would be to…”

To respond to a question:

- “Good question. The short answer is…”
- “I’d need to check, but my understanding is…”
- “Let me come back to you on that.” (perfect when you need time)

To wrap up and set action items:

- “So, to summarise…”
- “The key takeaways are…”
- “Let’s agree on next steps.”
- “[Name], could you take the lead on…?”
- “Let’s follow up on this by [day].”
- “Thanks everyone — I’ll send a summary afterwards.”

“Let me come back to you on that” is especially useful: it’s a professional way to buy time instead of panicking when you’re put on the spot.

Speaking up with confidence

Knowing the phrases is half the battle; using them smoothly is the other half. A few tips:

- **Prepare one or two points before the meeting** and the phrase you'll use to raise them, so you're not composing under pressure.
- **Speak early.** The longer you wait to say your first thing, the harder it gets. A quick "That's a good point" in the first few minutes breaks the ice.
- **Keep it short.** You don't need long, complex sentences — a clear, short contribution lands better than a rambling one.
- **Rehearse the phrases out loud** until they come automatically, so they're ready when the moment arrives.

That last point is where practice matters. With an AI speaking partner like Yappply, you can role-play a meeting — giving an update, disagreeing politely, handling a question — as many times as you want, so these phrases feel natural before you use them for real. Rehearsing the exact situations you'll face is the fastest way to stop freezing in meetings.

Frequently asked questions

How can I speak more confidently in English meetings? Learn ready-made phrases for each moment (opening, giving opinions, disagreeing, clarifying, wrapping up), prepare a point or two in advance, and speak early. Having phrases ready means you focus on your idea, not on finding words.

How do I disagree politely in a meeting in English? Acknowledge the other person first, then give your view: "I see your point, but…" or "That's one option, though another way to look at it is…" Jumping straight to "you're wrong" sounds harsh in English.

What do I say when I don't understand something in a meeting? Ask — it's normal and professional. Use "Sorry, could you clarify what you mean by…?" or "Just to make sure I understand, are you saying…?"

What can I say when I'm put on the spot and need time? "Let me come back to you on that" or "I'd need to check, but my understanding is…" Both buy you time professionally instead of panicking.

How do I practise English for meetings? Role-play the situations out loud — giving an update, disagreeing, answering a question — until the phrases come automatically. A partner or an AI speaking app that can role-play meetings is ideal for this.